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오징어 게임:¹ **Ethics, Privacy and Technology in *Squid Game***

Abstract: This paper analyzes the role of ethics, privacy and technology in *Netflix*'s South Korean survival drama, *Squid Game* (2021). The show's popularity hinges on its mordant critique of capitalism, particularly the global disappearance of the middle class. This tension between personal and communal survival intersects with despair, surveillance and the illusion of consent.

Keywords: *Squid Game*, South Korea, *Netflix*, Marxism, ethics, privacy, media, technology.

I. Introduction

Squid Game, the South Korean survival drama created by Hwang Dong-hyuk for *Netflix*, premiered on September 17, 2021. By November of the same year, the show had amassed 1.65 billion watch hours within the first 28 days of its release, making it the service's most watched series to date (Spangler). The story follows 456 indebted "volunteers" who "choose" to play childhood games. The twist lies in that each player's death adds ₩100 million (\$8,949.78) to the potential ₩45.6 billion grand prize (\$3,742,636.82)--winner or winners take all. Divorced father Seong Gi-hun (Lee Jung-jae), is our window into the abyss as player 456. After being kidnapped,

¹ 오징어 게임, pronounced "Ojing-eo Geim."

he awakes within an secret island complex where six death games take place. The contestants' clothing is replaced with teal tracksuits while they are unconscious, a chilling reminder that, in *Squid Game*, bodies are not persons. They are living currency. The games are directed by the Front Man to entertain billionaire sponsors, the VIPs, who wear golden masks.

The show's social critique hinges on capitalism's systemic cannibalization of a shrinking middle class within South Korea and beyond--a process intercepted by real-world concerns over the ethics of privacy and technology. The character's roles on the island are mirrored in the costume design, which in turn parodies capitalistic class structures problematized by Marxist scholarship. Current ethical privacy and technology concerns are reflected in contestant's "agreement" to play childhood games to the death. Despair, surveillance, and the illusion of consent perpetrate the ever increasing power that user-generated content allocates to algorithmic profit-driven media behemoths like Google, Apple and Meta. The survivalism genre's dystopian call to action--to remedy asymmetrical distribution of wealth and power--converges with our collective impotence at being trapped in a tiered social system where few have lots, and many have little.

II. *Squid Game*'s Caste System: From Disposable to Untouchable

The ethics of "consent to play" permeate the entire narrative of *Squid Game*. Through a color-coded caste system, characters are divided into three categories corresponding with the amount of power they wield over other lives. Unilateral adherence to socially contractual roles legitimizes the game's systemic violence. As previously mentioned, the indebted contestants wear teal tracksuits, each with a number between 1 and 456. In Marxist scholarship,² the lowest tier of characters corresponds with the working class *proletariat*. Essential, blue and immigrant

² "*Squid Game*'s Caste System" chart is based on the "Marxist Approach" chapter in *Critical Media Studies: An Introduction* by Brian L. Ott & Robert L. Mack, pp. 24–60.

workers constitute this population, always the most numerous in both the show and contemporary societies. Seong Gi-hun, in episode 5, “A Fair World,” mentions that watch duty in the communal dormitory reminds him of participating in the 77-day long Ssangyong Motors workers strike in 2009.³ Unionized factory workers like Seong Gi-hun have been the quintessential agents of proletariat activism since the nineteenth century.

<i>Squid Game's</i> Color Caste System				
Characters	Symbols	Class	Role	Marxist scholarship
TEAL				
Contestants	Numbers 1-456	Destitute, indebted, formerly middle class	Survive <i>Squid Game</i> and collect the cash price representing each peer's death.	Proletariat - essential workers, blue-collar workers, immigrants
MAGENTA				
Masked Guards	● worker	PERHAPS also destitute, indebted, formerly middle class	Must remain masked or die, eat/sleep along in cells, cook, clean, herd and kill uncooperative/disqualified contestants. Led by Front Man.	Petit bourgeoisie - merchants and white collar workers
	▲ soldier			
	■ manager			
GOLD				
Masked VIPs	Lion Bull Panther Eagle	Oligarchs & Multinationals	Billionaires financing and enjoying the death games, past and present. They arrive on site for entertainment, libations and abuse.	Bourgeoisie - sometimes people, but mostly corporations owning the means of production & shareholders.

The second largest group of characters--the *petit bourgeoisie*--are the guards. Although they all wear magenta jumpsuits, the designs on their helmets differentiate them in terms of rank

³ “Amid August heatwaves, yellow tear-gas liquid cascaded down on us from the sky. Swooping police choppers whipped up wind sufficient to pull umbrellas from our feeble hands. Riot police scaled the factory fences like invading cockroaches. Armed police commands fired rubber bullets and stormed the rooftop of the factory from freight containers pulled up by giant cranes. They brandished their clubs over our heads as they chased us. Police were trampling us, beating us, and continuing to beat us even after we fell unconscious. We were flipping and tumbling like origami in the ddakji game that a mysterious recruiter used to attract contestants in *Squid Game*” (Chang-Kun).

and duty. Higher tiers correspond with an increase in shape angles (circle/worker, triangle/soldier, square/manager). It is no accident that the Front Man's mask has the most angles, reminiscent of Cubism, to underline his leadership. Merchants and professional white collar workers align with the masked guards in that *perhaps* they are also destitute, indebted, and formerly middle class. Just like the players, the guards are hostages. Their "consent" to participate is a product of systemic violence that strips everyone but the wealthiest of personal sovereignty. In episode 3, "The Man with the Umbrella," a player who is about to be executed takes a guard's firearm and unmask him, revealing a young man barely out of high school. Overwhelmed, the contestant shoots himself. The youth is executed in cold blood for revealing his identity.

The game's *bourgeoise* sponsors, whose golden masks each depict a different power animal (lion, bull, panther, eagle), arrive on the island to wager in person during episode 7, "VIPs." The billionaires watch the spectacle from a private suite, where we witness a bacchanal of disregard for human life ripe with toxic masculinity. The evocation of totem animals, on the one hand, recalls heraldry. On the other hand, adopting a powerful symbol makes corporations distinctive, memorable and profitable. Emblems are essential to social stratification. Whether oligarchs or multinational corporations, emblemized social sectors that own the means of production also control the media professions.⁴ We, the teals and the magentas, are toys for the powerful, implies the show's writer. "I wanted to create something that would resonate not just for Korean people but globally," says Hwang Dong-hyuk, in an article for *The Guardian*. "I do believe that the overall global economic order is unequal and that around 90% of the people believe that it's unfair. During the pandemic, poorer countries can't get their people vaccinated.

⁴ See Table 2.2 "The Big Six US-based media conglomerates (2018)," about the media industry's vertical integration, in *Critical Media Studies*, 33-4.

They're contracting viruses on the streets and even dying. So I did try to convey a message about modern capitalism. As I said, it's not profound" (Stuart).

III. Ethics, Privacy and Technological Concerns in *Squid Game*

A. Despair

The asymmetrical economic world order Hwang Dong-hyuk references thrives in the public availability of personal and financial information. Data-gathering enables the *Squid Game* algorithm to target potential contestants based on their degree of despair. In "Privacy and Participation in the Cloud: Implications in Google Privacy Practices and Public Communications," Robert Bodle details the threats to privacy inherent in cloud computing, or Web 2.0. This "new" 2010s-2020s Web 2.0 differs from the 1990s-2000s Web 1.0 in that user-generated content sites, social networks, and microblogs⁵ increasingly depend on sharing personal information while downplaying privacy protection (157). The algorithmic selection that informs *Squid Game* is a reflection of a contestant's online presence built from consensual sharing of personal information.

The aggregated data operates in the same fashion as targeted advertisement, which, were it not for public pressure, would be completely devoid of ethical boundaries. Irina Raicu argues that "even users in a single region of the world (or a single room) are already likely to be shown very different search results--unless they've actively taken steps to turn off the "personalized search" that Google implements as its default setting." Most people do not know that one may turn off Google's personalized search, let alone how to disengage it. In the pivotal scene where Seong Gi-hun recalls the Ssangyong Motors strike, we learn that in 2009 the company

⁵ Since the publication of *Ethics of Emerging Media* in 2011, the distinction between user-generated content sites (YouTube), social networks (Facebook) and microblogs (Twitter) is now obsolete. YouTube, Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, Pinterest, LinkedIn, SnapChat, Google Spaces, Canva, TikTok, etc. are all user-generated social network microblogs. Perhaps it is time to upgrade the phenomenon to Web 3.0, or the hyper vertical integration of the internet.

unexpectedly laid off 2,646 employees to facilitate profit transfers to global investors, which led to 77-days of worker unrest. The strike and its aftermath, which correlates with the Web 2.0 years, played out online. The workers' personal information generated from the event made thousands "unemployable" by association, leading many to commit suicide.⁶ In their case, omitting ethical privacy protections for user-generated content continues to be lethal. Seong Gi-hun's algorithmically quantifiable despair, not the man, is the protagonist of *Squid Game*.

B. Surveillance

Despair's handmaiden in our increasingly authoritarian world is surveillance. In *Squid Game*, surveillance is employed to learn about a contestant's relations, patterns, movements, longings and fears, when the information is not publicly available. Katherine G. Vazquez, in "The Right to Be Forgotten Does Not Apply outside the European Union: A Proposal for Worldwide Application," asserts that Google and other "controllers" are a "quasi-judicial authority" because they determine "what constitutes private information or not" (2021). Vazquez's proposal analyzes the right granted by the European Union to have search engines delist certain results based on a person's name upon request. The "right to be forgotten" is a far cry from the lack of ethics-informed government regulation over personal privacy in communication technologies in both the USA and South Korea.

For one particular contestant--no. 067--the omnipresence of surveillance within and beyond *Squid Game* has always been a matter of life and death. Kang Sae-byeok (HoYeon Jung) is a North Korean defector. Risking her life in *Squid Game* is preferable to constantly evading detection by Pyongyang's secret service. North Korea is the infamous antithesis to ethics in

⁶ "Thirteen SsangYong workers and family members died by suicide as a result of this anti-union oppression between 2009 and 2011. One worker's final statement read, "My salary was reduced dramatically, and it is painful to feed my kids ramen (instant noodles) because I can't afford to buy rice." Another worker told his wife, "I am leaving you debts only until the last moment. I am so sorry." Between 2009 and 2018, another 30 SsangYong workers committed suicide for similar reasons" (Ji).

technology and personal privacy. Defectors so dread the penalty of torture and slow execution that suicide is preferable to being caught. North Korea hunts down defectors *within* South Korea and other sovereign nations to extradite them for execution. Kang Sae-byeok is a survivalist on the run, successfully evading the North Korean government for years, yet *Squid Game*'s sophisticated algorithm (like Google) has no problem finding her. This for-profit extra-legal gladiatorial travesty complete with golden Caesars operates with a surveillance system far more sophisticated than sovereign nations' communication technologies. Governments, after all, run on Google.

C. Consent

The tension between individual vs. communal survival becomes a pointless spectacle when “the illusion of “choice” justifies all manner of exploitation” (Quinn). It might be easy to dismiss self-exploitation as fiction; however, Hwang Dong-hyuk achieved a series that resonates globally for three very real reasons. First, we experience catharsis from watching the contestants and guards play to the death. That “phew, not me” is a pressure valve that relieves tensions to make tedious life slightly more livable. Second, over the last four decades the middle class has shrunk to non-existence, widening the wealth gap between have and have-nots. Third, Seong Gi-hun's desperate choice to win the prize or die trying is not unthinkable, it is chillingly *plausible*.

Life, at this juncture of “consent,” loses all meaning. In *Squid Game*, three simple terms and conditions apply. In this code of ethics, players,

1. Must compete in the game,
2. Will be terminated if they stop competing, and
3. Can terminate the game if the majority of contestants agree.

In episode 2, “Hell,” survivors of the first game put the third clause to a vote and narrowly canceled the game, with everyone returning to their daily lives. For Seong Gi-hun and Kang Sae-byeok, desperation and surveillance mean their bodies are the only commodity they have left. Risking death is preferable to dying slowly by a thousand cuts in a capitalist world. We, in turn, agree to a *Squid Game* reality of exchanging personal information, habits and patterns with controllers for “free” services where we, the users, are the traded commodity. In this context, users assume the responsibility for their own data protections through the “transparency of choice” (Bodle 157).

IV. Conclusion

Former Ssangyong Motors factory worker, Lee Chang-Kun, reacts to *Squid Game* with frustration, “even empty[ness]... Inequality in my country now appears solidified beyond the point of reversal, with the rich getting richer and the poor getting poorer, while the story of the Ssangyong workers is a disposable commodity in a *Netflix* show.” The survivors of the 2009 workers’ strike, through the show’s global success, are worth 1.65 billion watch hours of profit for the streaming service. To date, *Netflix* has not translated any of the revenue into assisting the community most affected by the historical events that inform *Squid Game*. Capitalism’s systemic cannibalization of dilapidated global middle classes overlaps with contemporary ethical concerns over privacy, technology and media. In a world where many increasingly have very little, and a shrinking few gradually own more and more of the means of production, the Web 2.0 (3.0?)⁷ buys us little by little with every like, share, and subscribe.

⁷ See footnote 5.

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